A CATHOLIC INTRODUCTION TO AI · CLASS 5

What Shapes a Chatbot's Answer

The design decisions you control, and the ones you don't

SAME QUESTION, DIFFERENT ANSWERS

Every answer is shaped by two layers of decisions

Decisions you make

- Signed in or signed out
- Chat history, or a fresh chat
- Your “profile”: memory and custom instructions
- Settings: model, search, style

Decisions the company makes

- What data the model learned from
- How it was trained to sound and behave
- Hidden instructions it receives
- What it declines, softens, or adds warnings to.

FACTOR 1 · ACCOUNT

Signed in or signed out

Signed in

- Saved memories can shape answers
- Custom instructions apply to every chat
- Past chats may be referenced
- Paid plans may get stronger models

Signed out

- No memory or custom instructions
- Often a different or smaller model
- Fewer features and tighter limits
- Closest to a blank slate, but not neutral

FACTOR 2 · CHAT HISTORY

A new chat clears the conversation, not the memory

Inside one chat

Every earlier message is sent back with each new question. An early tone, topic or mistake carries forward.

Across chats

The conversation resets, but saved memories and custom instructions can still follow you in.

From the lab: Starting a new chat for each question is a good practice, but it is only a "clean" slate if memory is off.

What the chatbot keeps about you

Saved memories

Facts the bot stored from earlier chats, like your job or interests.

Custom instructions

Standing rules a user wrote, like “be brief” or “I’m Catholic.”

Past-chat search

Some bots look back through your earlier conversations.

To remove the "profile": sign out, or use a temporary or incognito chat.

FACTOR 4 · SETTINGS

The switches that change the answer

Setting	What it changes	What you might see
Model or mode	Which model answers, and how long it “thinks”	Fast mode is short; reasoning mode is longer
Web search	Live web pages vs. trained knowledge only	Citations appear (like Copilot’s)
Style or tone	Length, formality and formatting	One sentence vs. headers and bullets
Temporary chat	Ignores memory and saves no history	A cleaner, less personal answer

Setting names change often; check each product’s menu before a lab.

BEYOND YOUR CONTROL

What no setting can change

Training data

What the model read, and whose views it contains

Fine-tuning

The tone, values and habits it was trained to show

System prompt

Hidden instructions from the company in every chat

Safety policies

What it refuses, softens or adds caveats to

Randomness

The same question asked twice gets different wording

The takeaway

Signing out does not remove any biased. It is still based on training data.

Who controls each factor, and how to test fairly

Factor	Who controls it	How to handle it in a lab
Signed in or out	You	Sign out of every chatbot, or none
Chat history	You	Start a new chat for each question
Profile and memory	You, partly	Use temporary chat, or sign out
Settings	You	Record the model and whether search was on
Company design	The company	Can’t remove it; compare products to reveal it
Randomness	No one	Ask each question twice and compare

FOR DISCUSSION

If you sign out of every chatbot, have you removed bias, or only personalization?

1. Whose choices still shape the answer after you sign out?
2. Which of these factors should companies have to disclose to users?
3. What would Catholic Social Teaching say about who may see and control a person's chatbot "profile"?